

Facebook will die... soon

By analyzing MySpace data, a Princeton researcher predicted the end of Facebook akin to a disease:
<http://dgit.in/1f8m5nV>

R.I.P scams up

Symantec claims on its blog that social media sites are witnessing an upsurge of Rest In Peace scams that fakely allege the death of popular celebs

identifying the location of the sensation. The next step for these researchers is to simulate signals that identify the shape, size and material of the object.

COMPUTER-CONTROLLED PROSTHETICS

Another issue with prosthetic limbs is that they can't exactly replicate the nimble and natural movements of a real one. Researchers at the Michigan Technological University are solving this problem by developing a microprocessor-controlled leg that has an ankle that can move from side to side to adjust to the terrain. The pressure sensors at the bottom of the prosthetic send relevant information to the microprocessor which then adjusts the angle of the foot via the ankle for a more natural-walking feel.

APP-CONTROLLED HAND

And yes, bionics have entered even the Apple ecosystem. Introducing Touch Bionics' i-limb – the app controlled prosthetic hand that can be configured for a variety of tasks via the tap on the app which is compatible with iPads and iPhones. While the hand is controlled via signals that come through electrode attached to the user's stump and picks up electric signals, the Quick Grip biosim app connects via bluetooth to the hand and can be used to apply 24 pre-programmed grip options like typing, using a mouse, holding paper, etc.

Prosthetics are not just limited to what you have read here. Around the world, people have been getting replacements for bones, skull plates etc but these are mostly non-moving parts.

EXOSKELETONS

Now a topic that would make any Iron Man fan stand up and take notice - Exoskeletons. Most of us can't wait to become Iron Men ourselves and are anxiously waiting for the day that technology enables us to do so. That being said, there are various developments around the world that also focus on developing exoskeletons that help people in walk again or assist in medical care. Here are a few of these exoskeletons which might become common in the near future.

Military

Although nowhere near the superhuman abilities of Iron Man, military exoskeletons match it in one area – super strength. The two major military exoskeletons in development are the XOS by Raytheon and the Human Universal Load Carrier (HULC by) Lockheed-Martin. While the HULC focuses on the



Exoskeletons – Elysium, much?

legs and back, the XOS focuses on all, the arms, legs and back.

The HULC, which is made up of powered titanium legs, enables a soldier to carry up to 200 pounds of weight over any terrain. It is a flexible hydraulic-powered anthropomorphic exoskeleton that allows the soldier to perform deep squats, crawls, and most other battlefield movements.

Like the HULC, the XOS exoskeleton is also capable of allowing the user to lift 200 pounds or weight. Wearing the exoskeleton, the user can run, walk and even rebalance if he/she stumbles. The XOS is

a versatile exoskeleton and allows the wearer to perform a wide variety of nimble actions like climbing stairs, kicking a football or punching through wood (Heck yeah, this is what we want). Expected to join service in 2015, the XOS is powered by internal combustion hydraulics engine with electrical systems. Computer processors are present in every joint of the suit.

Multipurpose

Quite frankly, at the moment, exoskeletons are needed much more in civilian life than on battlefield (not saying that a kick-ass robosuit isn't important, but lets help humanity first). Exoskeletons can serve multiple purposes in civilian life like medical care, disaster-fighting, and areas where the strength provided by an exoskeleton is of maximum use.

For example: A mix of all the popular sci-fi movies, the Hybrid Assistive Limb or HAL: (yes, we all had the same 'Aha' moment) built by Cyberdyne Inc (if they develop an AI, run, if you want to live) is robotic suit that enhances or extends the body's functions. It is also the first personal exoskeleton to receive a global certificate and was used in disaster fighting in the Fukushima nuclear plant disaster in 2011.

HAL is being used in hospitals across Japan where it is being used by people with muscle weakness and by people with disabilities due to spinal cord injuries, etc. HAL interprets the electrical signals around the skin where there is muscle damage and moves accordingly.

In conclusion, the field of advanced prosthetics is already vast, and growing. There are bionic eyes, livers, blood vessels, stem cells out there and who knows what other organ we might print/create someday. Things can only get better in the future (imagine nanobots that enable shape changing bionics that would move, feel and look like the real thing). Picture a time when we will have our own Elysium suits like Matt Damon.

But to end this with a little food for thought: after this human/machine integration, will we be machines or humans when most of our parts get replaced/enhanced? Should we avoid being assimilated or is resistance truly futile? 